



Sumo

roots go back nearly 1,500 years and the ritual has changed little. The sport reflects many values that the Japanese hold dear, such as respect and rank, and sumo wrestlers are considered to be living heroes. There are six Grand Tournaments every year, each one lasting for 15 days.

SUMO WRESTLING is the extraordinary and exciting national sport of Japan. Its



THE WEIGHT

In sumo, the larger the man the better. There are no weight limits so it is possible for a wrestler to find himself fighting a component twice his weight. The average weight of a wrestler is about 350 lb (158 kg). One of the largest wrestlers ever was 700 lb (317 kg)!

Large banners announce sumo tournaments.

PREPARATION

Before the match each sumo wrestler's hair is tied into a top knot, called a *mage*. The knot is slightly different according to the seniority of the wrestler. The *mawashi*, or loin cloth—the only piece of clothing worn during the match—is made from 30 ft (10 m) of black silk.

